

Ἰσοκράτης ὁ Ἀθηναῖος

Pan-Hellenic Oratory and Education in Isocrates of Athens

eul_aid: ffu

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)

Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#)

Domain: [Ῥητορική](#) [Oratory](#)

Format: [Λόγος](#) [Oration](#)

Isocrates was an Athenian orator, rhetorician, and educator who lived from 436 to 338 BCE. Born into a wealthy family, he lost his fortune due to the Peloponnesian War and its aftermath, which led him to begin his career writing speeches for others to use in court.

Around 392 BCE, he founded a highly successful school of rhetoric and philosophy in Athens. Unlike many teachers of his time, he did not focus on training for lawsuits. Instead, his school provided a broad political education aimed at future leaders, emphasizing moral character and practical wisdom alongside skill in speaking. Although he was not a public speaker himself, he exerted influence through widely circulated written works.

Twenty-one orations and nine letters survive under his name, though the authenticity of some letters is debated. His early works include legal speeches, while his later and more significant works are political discourses and display pieces. These major writings, such as the Panegyricus and To Philip, are carefully crafted essays on Athenian politics and Greek unity.

Isocrates is historically important for three main reasons. First, as an educator, he established a model of higher education focused on rhetoric and leadership that rivaled Plato's Academy and influenced later Greek and Roman teaching. Second, his prose style—known for its complex, rhythmic sentences—became a standard model for later oratory and literature. Third, he was a major advocate for panhellenism, the idea of Greek city-states uniting. He first promoted Athenian leadership in this cause and later supported Philip II of Macedon as a unifying force. He died in 338 BCE, shortly after the Battle of Chaeronea. Modern scholars see his ideas as a significant part of the intellectual landscape that shaped the 4th century BCE.

Works (31)

- [Κατὰ Λοχίτου](#) · [Against Lochites](#) · 16 passages
- [Κατὰ τοῦ Σοφιστῶν](#) · [Against The Sophists](#) · 15 passages
- [Ἀρχίδαμος](#) · [Archidamus](#) · 74 passages
- [Ἀρεοπαγитικός](#) · [Areopagiticus](#) · 55 passages
- [Τραπεζитικός](#) · [Banker](#) · 45 passages
- [Βούσιρις](#) · [Busiris](#) · 34 passages
- [παράγραφος πρὸς καλλίμαχον](#) · [Counterplea To Callimachus](#) · 48 passages
- [Εὐαγόρας](#) · [Evagoras](#) · 47 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Ῥητορικῆς Θεωρίας](#) · [Fragments on Rhetorical Theory](#) · 40 passages

- [Ελένη · Helena](#) · 40 passages
- [Νικόκλης ἢ Κύπριοι · Nicocles or the Cyprians](#) · 50 passages
- [Περὶ ἀντιδόσεως · On Exchange](#) · 201 passages
- [Περὶ ἵππων ζεύγους · On Pair of Horses](#) · 32 passages
- [Περὶ εἰρήνης · On Peace](#) · 82 passages
- [Αἰγητικός · On the Goat](#) · 40 passages
- [Παναθηγητικός · Panathenaicus](#) · 147 passages
- [Πανηγυρικός · Panegyricus](#) · 115 passages
- [Φίλιππος · Philip](#) · 100 passages
- [Παναθηναϊκός · Plataikos](#) · 36 passages
- [Ἀλεξάνδρῳ · To Alexander](#) · 3 passages
- [Ἀντιπάτρῳ · To Antipater](#) · 8 passages
- [Ἀρχιδάμῳ · To Archidamus](#) · 10 passages
- [Προς Δημονικόν · To Demonicus](#) · 43 passages
- [Πρὸς Διονύσιον · To Dionysius](#) · 9 passages
- [προς ευθύνουν · To Euthynus](#) · 19 passages
- [Τῷ Νικοκλεί · To Nicocles](#) · 39 passages
- [Φιλίπῳ α · To Philip I](#) · 17 passages
- [Φιλίπῳ β · To Philip II](#) · 7 passages
- [τοῖς Μυτιληναίων ἄρχουσιν · To the Rulers of Mytilene](#) · 11 passages
- [τοῖς Ἰάσονος παισίν · To the Sons of Jason](#) · 12 passages
- [Τιμοθέῳ · To Timothy](#) · 11 passages